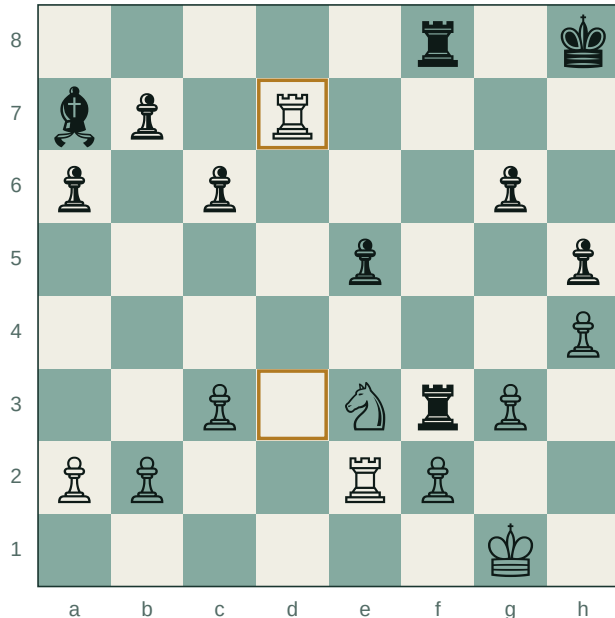


Capture the defender: Black, move 29

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 29.Rd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29...Rxf2 30. Rxf2 Bxe3

29...Rxf2 The rook captures the pawn on f2. Recorded reply: **30.Rxf2**.

30...Bxe3 The bishop captures the knight on e3.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 14 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from +0 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on d7 and rook on e2. Check for tactical protection.